

Your Workplace Rights With Arthritis: The Equality Act 2010

Reasonable adjustments are a legal entitlement, not a favour.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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Overview



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Reasonable adjustments are a legal entitlement, not a favour.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/finances\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team from UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. Pending clinical review. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews consistently highlight the importance of early intervention and ongoing management in arthritis care. While there's no single cure, research from numerous randomised trials shows that a combination of pharmacological and non-pharmacological treatments can significantly reduce pain, improve function, and enhance quality of life for people living with various forms of arthritis.

Clinical guidelines from professional bodies reinforce this, recommending a personalised approach. This includes careful diagnosis, medication tailored to the individual's condition and symptoms, and a strong emphasis on self-management strategies. Evidence also points to the benefits of regular physical activity adapted to individual capabilities, education about the condition, and psychological support where needed.

The effectiveness of 'reasonable adjustments' in the workplace, for instance, is supported by evidence demonstrating that flexible working conditions and ergonomic adaptations can reduce absenteeism, improve productivity, and help retain experienced employees living with long-term health conditions. This isn't just about compliance; it's about creating a sustainable, inclusive work environment.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Ignoring early symptoms:** Hoping pain will resolve on its own can delay effective treatment. *Fix: See a doctor for persistent joint pain or swelling.* **Overdoing it on good days:** Pushing through pain can lead to flare-ups and setbacks. *Fix: Pace yourself and listen to your body, even when you feel well.* **Stopping medication too soon:** Feeling better often means the medication is working, not that you no longer need it. *Fix: Always discuss medication changes with your doctor.* **Neglecting regular movement:** Fear of pain can lead to inactivity, worsening stiffness and weakness. *Fix: Engage in gentle, low-impact exercise regularly.* **Lacking self-advocacy:** Not clearly communicating your needs or asking for help. *Fix: Prepare for appointments and be clear about how arthritis affects your daily life.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

While managing arthritis often involves day-to-day self-care, certain symptoms or changes warrant prompt medical advice. Catching potential issues early can prevent further complications and ensure your treatment plan remains effective.

* Sudden, severe joint pain or swelling that doesn't improve with rest. * New symptoms like fever, chills, or unexplained weight loss accompanying joint pain. * Rapid loss of function or mobility in a joint. * Side effects from medication that are concerning or severely impacting your daily life. * Your current treatment plan no longer seems to be managing your symptoms effectively.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can arthritis affect my ability to do my job? Yes, arthritis can impact various aspects of your work, including physical tasks, concentration, and energy levels. However, many people with arthritis work successfully, often with the help of adjustments and support.

What kind of "reasonable adjustments" can I ask for at work? Reasonable adjustments are changes that help you do your job effectively. Examples include flexible working hours, ergonomic equipment (like a special chair or keyboard), adjusted duties, or even a change of workstation.

Do I have to tell my employer I have arthritis? You are not legally obliged to disclose your arthritis unless it poses a health and safety risk. However, telling your employer can help them understand your needs and allow you to request reasonable adjustments.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about your workplace rights with arthritis: the equality act 2010?

Short answer: Arthritis can impact work performance due to its effects on physical tasks, concentration, and energy levels. Many individuals with arthritis work successfully, often with workplace adjustments. Reasonable adjustments, which are a legal entitlement, include

flexible hours, ergonomic equipment, and adjusted duties. You do not have to disclose your arthritis to your employer unless it poses a health and safety risk.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk